Running Footwear Category Deep Dive

JD Sports UK | H1 FY2027 (February to July 2026)

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1. Executive Summary

The running footwear category generated GBP 226 million in revenue during H1 2026, representing 104.6% of the GBP 216 million plan and growth of 15.0% versus the prior year period.

Running footwear is the fastest growing subcategory within footwear, growing at 15.0% year on year compared to total footwear growth of 4.2%. Running now accounts for 17.0% of total footwear revenue, up from 15.5% in the prior year.

The growth is driven by three factors. Technical innovation in midsole foam and carbon plate technology is driving replacement cycles. The running boom that began during the pandemic has sustained. New brands, particularly Hoka and On Running, are attracting new customers into the category.

Gross margin for the category was 44.0%, 0.5 percentage points below the footwear average of 44.5%. The margin pressure comes from higher promotional activity on premium technical product.

H1 Revenue: GBP 226 million (104.6% of plan)

YoY Growth: +15.0%

Share of Total Footwear: 17.0% (up from 15.5%)

Category Gross Margin: 44.0%

2. Brand Share Analysis

Nike (39.8% of category - GBP 90 million)

Growth of 8.0% versus prior year. Gross margin of 45.0%. The Pegasus franchise is the cornerstone with the Pegasus 41 generating GBP 8.2 million in H1. Nike leads the category but is losing share to faster-growing challenger brands.

Adidas (21.7% of category - GBP 49 million)

Growth of 6.0% versus prior year. The Ultraboost Light remains the bestselling Adidas running model, but the franchise faces increasing competition from newer products.

ASICS (14.2% of category - GBP 32 million)

Growth of 24.0% versus prior year, making ASICS the second fastest growing brand. The Gel Kayano 31 and Novablast 4 were both top 10 SKUs. ASICS has strong brand equity in the serious runner segment with high customer satisfaction and repeat purchase rates.

Hoka (8.8% of category - GBP 20 million)

Growth of 52.0% versus prior year, making Hoka the fastest growing brand. The Clifton 9 and Bondi 8 were the top sellers. Hoka is currently in only 85 stores, and supply constraints have been the limiting factor rather than demand. Significant opportunity exists to expand distribution.

New Balance (7.7% of category - GBP 17.5 million)

Growth of 18.0% versus prior year. The Fresh Foam X 1080v13 is the top seller. Strong momentum in the premium segment.

On Running (6.0% of category - GBP 13.5 million)

Growth of 35.0% versus prior year. The Cloudstratus 3 and Cloudmonster are the top sellers. Strong brand awareness among younger runners with premium technical positioning.

Saucony (1.1%) and Brooks (0.7%)

Both brands have loyal but small customer bases. Limited brand awareness among the broader JD customer base limits their growth potential in the current ranging.

3. Price Architecture

Running footwear is segmented into four price tiers based on recommended retail price.

The Core tier (GBP 60 to GBP 89) accounts for 22.0% of units and 15.0% of revenue. Gross margin is 42.0%. This tier includes models like the Nike Revolution and Adidas Duramo. Important for attracting new runners but limited profitability.

The Mid tier (GBP 90 to GBP 129) accounts for 30.0% of units and 28.0% of revenue. Gross margin is 44.0%. Models include the Nike Pegasus and ASICS Cumulus. This is the volume heartland of the category.

The Premium tier (GBP 130 to GBP 179) accounts for 32.0% of units and 38.0% of revenue. Gross margin is 45.5%. Models include the ASICS Nimbus, Hoka Clifton, and On Cloudstratus. This is the most profitable tier and the one with the strongest growth trajectory.

The Super Premium tier (GBP 180 and above) accounts for 16.0% of units and 19.0% of revenue. Gross margin is 47.0%. Models include the Nike Alphafly, Hoka Bondi, and On Cloudboom. Highest margins but also the highest markdown risk.

4. Top 10 SKUs

1. Nike Pegasus 41 (GBP 120). Revenue GBP 8.2 million, 68,000 pairs. The most consistent seller in the running category, appealing to both casual and serious runners.

2. ASICS Gel Kayano 31 (GBP 155). Revenue GBP 5.6 million, 36,000 pairs. Market leader in the stability running shoe segment with a fiercely loyal customer base.

3. Hoka Clifton 9 (GBP 130). Revenue GBP 4.9 million, 38,000 pairs. Entry point to the Hoka brand for many new customers.

4. Adidas Ultraboost Light (GBP 140). Revenue GBP 4.6 million, 33,000 pairs. Strong performer facing increasing competition.

5. Nike Vomero 17 (GBP 140). Revenue GBP 4.1 million, 29,000 pairs. Nike's premium cushioned running shoe.

6. New Balance Fresh Foam X 1080v13 (GBP 145). Revenue GBP 3.8 million, 26,000 pairs.

7. ASICS Novablast 4 (GBP 135). Revenue GBP 3.1 million, 23,000 pairs. Popular for faster training.

8. On Cloudstratus 3 (GBP 165). Revenue GBP 3.2 million, 19,000 pairs.

9. Hoka Bondi 8 (GBP 150). Revenue GBP 2.9 million, 19,000 pairs. Maximum cushion shoe.

10. Nike Invincible 3 (GBP 160). Revenue GBP 2.7 million, 17,000 pairs.

5. Size Curve Analysis

The size curve for running footwear shows significant regional variation. Across the UK, the top selling sizes are UK 10 at 14.2% of volume, UK 9 at 13.8%, UK 11 at 12.1%, and UK 8 at 11.5%. The slowest selling sizes are UK 6 at 3.2% and UK 14 at 1.8%.

In Scotland, the curve shifts significantly towards larger sizes. UK 10 represents 16.1% of volume and UK 11 represents 14.2%. Combined, these two sizes account for over 30% of running shoe sales in Scotland, compared to 26.3% nationally.

In London and the South East, the curve shifts smaller. UK 9 represents 15.5% of volume and UK 8 represents 13.2%. The implication for stock allocation is clear. Scottish stores require significantly more large-size stock than the national average allocation.

6. Margin Analysis

The running footwear category achieved a gross margin of 44.0% in H1, 0.5 percentage points below the footwear average. Markdown erosion is the primary driver. The running category has a full-price sell-through rate of 68%, meaning that 32% of units are sold at a discount. For comparison, lifestyle footwear has a full-price sell-through rate of 82%.

The average discount depth on promoted running shoes is 24%, slightly deeper than the footwear average of 21%. ASICS achieves the highest running margin at 46.0%, driven by strong full-price demand. Hoka achieves 44.5%, lower due to higher promotional activity as the brand builds awareness. Nike running achieves 45.0% and Adidas running achieves 43.0%.

7. Competitor Pricing

The Nike Pegasus 41 is priced at GBP 120 at JD, GBP 120 at Nike.com, and GBP 115 at Sports Direct. JD is at parity with Nike direct but 4% above Sports Direct. This difference is acceptable given JD's superior service and return proposition.

The ASICS Gel Kayano 31 is priced at GBP 155 at JD and GBP 160 at ASICS.com. JD has a 3% price advantage over the brand's own channel. Sports Direct does not stock this model, giving JD a unique position.

The Hoka Clifton 9 is priced at GBP 130 at JD and GBP 130 at Hoka.com, at parity. Foot Locker also stocks this model at GBP 130. Limited availability across the market means price competition is less intense than for Nike products.

8. Stock Health

Running footwear stock at the end of H1 was GBP 78 million at retail value, representing 8.5 weeks of cover. The target is 7.5 weeks. Aged stock over 90 days represents 7.5% of running stock value, better than the total footwear aged stock figure of 9.8%.

The top 5 SKUs account for 24% of running stock value. This concentration risk means that stock issues with any of these key models have an outsized impact on the category.

9. Recommendations

Expand Hoka distribution from 85 stores to 200 stores. Hoka is growing at 52% year on year and supply constraints are the only barrier to growth. This should be the top priority for the buying team.

Increase the premium tier share from 38% to 42% of running revenue. The premium tier at GBP 130 to GBP 179 delivers the highest margins and the strongest growth.

Rebalance Scottish store size curves to increase UK 10 and UK 11 allocations by 20% and reduce UK 8 and UK 9 allocations by 15%. This could improve running category conversion in Scottish stores by an estimated 3% to 5%.

Implement a controlled price promotion on the Nike Pegasus 41 in January to clear aged stock ahead of the Pegasus 42 launch. A 25% discount for two weeks would clear an estimated 70% of aged stock.

Negotiate a 12-month exclusivity agreement with Hoka for the UK multibrand retail channel. Exclusivity would protect JD's margin on Hoka product and prevent price competition from other retailers.

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